



Shouldering the load

South Vietnamese volunteers carry ammunition for the Viet Cong on the Ho Chi Minh Trail. Armies of women helped distribute ammunition and weapons shipped to Hanoi from the Soviet Union and China.

Life on the trail

In the early days of the war, the trail was rudimentary. A North Vietnamese colonel called Bui Tin, traveling the trail in December 1961, recorded a trek lasting three months, during which he had to hack or crawl through the jungle. On a later trek, he recorded that some soldiers had lost their way and died of starvation. Travelers also faced venomous snakes, leeches, and dysentery.

As the war escalated, the demands made on the Ho Chi Minh Trail increased. In late 1963, Vo Bam's Group 559, which had been running the trail since its inception, investigated the feasibility of making it fit to transport large numbers of troops into South Vietnam. Five months later, Hanoi took the decision to transform the Trail into a sophisticated logistical network and put Colonel Dong Si Nguyen in charge of construction. Still underway a decade later, the trail became a spider's web of crisscrossing and intersecting tracks. Thousands of engineers toiled ceaselessly to widen and expand the trail. Equipped with modern Soviet and Chinese machinery, they carved out roads and built bridges that could handle heavy trucks and tanks. Convoys of vehicles, operating in relay, mostly at night, were soon transporting hundreds of tons of supplies southward.

TRUONG SON TRAIL The name given to the trail by the North Vietnamese, after the mountain range running through Central Vietnam. The Americans named it the Ho Chi Minh Trail.